

Divine Love

doc-divine-love

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.975
confidence high

Statement under examination

God is love in His very essence, eternally loving within the Trinity and toward His creatures.

In plain language

The Greek of First John 4:8 and 4:16 reads 'the God is love' (ho theos agape estin). The word-form analysis (morphology) settles the question of who is the subject: 'God' (theos) carries the article 'the' (ho theos) and 'love' (agape) does not, so the sentence means God is love, telling us what God is in his nature, not merely that he sometimes acts lovingly. The verb 'is' (estin) is the plain linking verb of being. The same writer builds the same kind of sentence when he says 'God is light' (ho theos phos estin) in First John 1:5, and John 4:24 does it with 'God is spirit' (pneuma ho theos). That parallel is the key to why careful readers still differ. The grammar clearly makes 'love' (agape) a defining predicate of God, but because the very same construction also predicates light and spirit, the words by themselves do not rank love above God's other essential qualities. So one reader hears love is the whole of God, another hears love is one of several things God essentially is, and both are reading the same grammar honestly. The wider canon settles the direction even if it leaves that ranking open. John 3:16 puts the love into action with the completed past verb 'he loved' (egapesen) and the giving of the one-of-a-kind Son ('only Son', monogenes). Romans 5:8 uses 'he demonstrates' (synistesin), to prove or demonstrate, and adds while we were still sinners, which rules out a love that waits for worthiness. John 17:24 reaches back before the foundation of the world, where the Father loved the Son ('you loved me', egapesas me), so the love is eternal, not switched on by creation. In the Old Testament the words 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) appears about two hundred forty seven times and the verb 'to love' (ahav) about two hundred nine times, and Exodus 34:6 places 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) at the center of God naming his own character. Texts where God hates, like Romans 9:13 ('Esau I hated', emisesa) and Psalm 5:5 ('you hate', sane), speak of elective preference and judicial opposition to evil and do not cancel the predicate. Across the Old Testament and the Gospels and the letters, the pattern is steady and dense. Love is not an occasional mood in God. It is part of what God is.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0157	אהב	'ahav	to love	209
H0160	אהבה	'ahavah	love	40
H2617	חסד	hesed	kindness	247
H7349	רחום	rachum	compassionate	
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	143
G0026	ἀγάπη	agapē	love	116
G1325	δίδωμι	didōmi	to give	
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457

G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,307
G3306	μένω	menō	to stay	118
G3439	μονογενής	monogenēs	unique	9
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuō	to trust (in)	
G4921	συνίστημι	synistēmi	to commend	16
G5207	υἱός	uhios	son	
G5547	Χριστός	Christos	Christ	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

In 1 John 4:8 and 4:16 the word-form analysis (morphology) gives an articular subject (a subject carrying the word 'the') 'the God' (ho theos, tagged T-NSM plus N-NSM) joined to a qualitative predicate noun without the article 'the' (anarthrous predicate nominative, a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) 'love' (agape, N-NSF), linked by the linking verb 'is' (copula) 'is' (estin, V-PAI-3S, ongoing simple statement of fact). This is the same construction the same author uses for 'the God is light' (ho theos phos estin) in 1 John 1:5 and that John 4:24 uses for 'spirit is the God' (pneuma ho theos), so love is predicated of God's nature, not reported as a mere occasional act. The proposition is non-convertible (it does not read 'the love is God', he agape theos estin), which forecloses a flat God-equals-love identity while affirming love as constitutive of the divine being. The pattern is pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible): the nouns and verbs for love 'love' (agape) and 'to love' (agapao) occur 116 and 143 times with God or Christ frequently as subject, the Hebrew 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed, 247 times) and 'to love' (ahav, 209 times) carry steadfast covenant love through the Old Testament, and Exodus 34:6 places 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) at the center of God's self-revelation. John 17:24 sets divine love before the foundation of the world.

Scripture

1John.4.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0026 ἀγάπη, G2316 θεός, G1510 εἰμί, G0025 ἀγαπάω

Force. Token word-form analysis (morphology) confirms 'the God' (ho theos) as T-NSM plus N-NSM (articular subject, a subject with the word 'the') with 'love' (agape) as N-NSF (anarthrous predicate nominative, a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement without the article 'the') and 'is' (estin) as V-PAI-3S (the simple linking verb 'is' of being, ongoing statement of fact). Article placement makes 'God' (theos) the subject and 'love' (agape) the qualitative predicate, so the clause states what God is in nature, not what he occasionally does. The negated converse 'the one not loving has not known the God' (ho me agapon ouk egno ton theon), with 'the one loving' (agapon) as V-PAP-NSM (a present participle, ongoing action functioning like a noun), ties knowing God inseparably to active loving.

1John.4.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0026 ἀγάπη, G2316 θεός, G3306 μένω, G4100 πιστεύω

Force. The formula 'the God is love' (ho theos agape estin) is repeated with identical word-form tagging (T-NSM, N-NSM, N-NSF, V-PAI-3S, ongoing statement of fact) and is framed by perfect verbs 'we have known' (egnokamen) and 'we have believed' (pepisteukamen, V-RAI-1P, completed action whose result still stands), signaling settled knowledge. The added clause 'the one abiding in the love abides in the God' (ho menon en te agape en to theo menei, 'to abide' meno as V-PAP-NSM and V-PAI-3S, an ongoing participle plus an ongoing main verb) makes abiding in love and abiding in God mutually entailing, so love is presented as both definitional of God and the locus of communion.

John.3.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0025 αγαπάω, G2316 θεός, G1325 δίδωμι, G3439 μονογενής

Force. The completed past action verb (aorist) 'he loved' (egapesen, V-AAI-3S, a completed past action) takes 'the God' (ho theos) as subject and 'the world' (ton kosmon) as object. The adverb 'thus' (Houtos) plus the result conjunction 'so that' (hoste) governs 'he gave' (edoken, V-AAI-3S, completed past action) and the giving of 'the one-of-a-kind Son' (ton huion ton monogene, where 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenes) is a 9-occurrence term, A-ASM, an adjective in the accusative case, the 'direct-object' grammatical form). Divine love is shown as self-giving and extended toward an undeserving world, putting the predicate of nature into concrete redemptive act.

Rom.5.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4921 συνίστημι, G0025 αγαπάω, G2316 θεός, G5547 Χριστός

Force. The ongoing present-tense verb 'he demonstrates' (synistesin, V-PAI-3S, ongoing simple statement of fact, meaning to demonstrate or establish by proof) takes 'his own love' (ten heautou agapen) as object, qualified by the genitive absolute (a noun-plus-participle construction set off in the 'from-X' grammatical form) 'while we were still sinners' (eti hamartolon onto hemon). The reflexive 'his own' (heautou) and the temporal qualifier place divine love logically prior to and independent of the worthiness of its object, ruling out merit-based or reactive readings of God's love. The 16-occurrence verb 'to demonstrate' (synistemi) is rare but its demonstrative sense is stable here.

John.17.24 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0025 αγαπάω, G3962 πατήρ

Force. 'you loved me before the foundation of the world' (egapesas me pro kataboles kosmou). The completed past action verb 'you loved' (egapesas, V-AAI-2S, a completed past action with 'you' as subject) has the Father as subject and the Son ('me', me) as object, qualified by 'before the foundation of the world' (pro kataboles kosmou). With John 17:26, where 'the love which you loved me' (he agape hen egapesas me) is to abide 'in them' (en autois), this anchors love within the Trinity as pre-temporal (before time) and not contingent on creation, supporting the 'eternally loving within the Trinity' clause of the proposition.

Exod.34.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H2617 טוב, H7349 מרחם

Force. The divine self-revelation 'YHWH YHWH God compassionate' (YHWH YHWH El rachum, H7349, compassionate) 'and gracious' (ve-channun, H2587, gracious) 'slow to anger and abounding in steadfast covenant love' (erekh appayim ve-rav hesed, H2617) 'and faithfulness' (ve-emet). Token word-form analysis shows 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) as a common-noun in the absolute state (the basic dictionary form) at the structural center of God's own name-disclosure. This grounds the New Testament love predicate in the Old Testament self-description of God's character and supplies the pan-canonical (spread across the whole Bible) breadth (Old Testament plus New Testament) the proposition requires.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
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1John.4.8	1John.4.16	openbible	45
1John.4.8	Ps.86.15	openbible	27
1John.4.8	Exod.34.6	openbible	19
1John.4.8	1John.1.5	openbible	15
1John.4.16	1John.4.9	tsk	1
John.3.16	Rom.5.8	openbible	962
John.3.16	1John.4.9	openbible	682
John.3.16	John.1.14	openbible	165
Rom.5.8	John.15.13	openbible	171
Rom.5.8	Isa.53.6	openbible	84

Complicating texts

Rom.9.13 · addressed

Token word-form analysis (morphology) gives 'Jacob I loved' (ton lakob egapesa, the verb 'to love' agapao, V-AAI-1S, a completed past action with 'I' as subject) 'but Esau I hated' (ton de Esau emisesa, the verb 'to hate' miseo, G3404, V-AAI-1S, completed past action). The same 'love' (agape) verb pairs with 'hate' (miseo) in a Semitic comparative idiom of elective preference (a Hebrew way of stating priority by stark contrast), the construction also seen in Luke 14:26 set beside Matthew 10:37 where 'he hates' (misei) and 'he does not love' (ou philei) mark relative priority. The text modulates the scope and economy of redemptive love but does not negate the predicate-nominative claim (the 'God is love' grammar) of 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, since the contrast is comparative election (a preference statement), not the denial that love is constitutive of God's nature.

Ps.5.5 · addressed

In the Masoretic versification (the standard Hebrew Bible numbering, here Psalm 5:6) 'you hate' (sane, H8130, V-Qal perfect 2ms, the simple active Hebrew verb form for 'you (masculine singular) have hated') takes 'all workers of iniquity' (kol poale aven) as object. This predicates judicial opposition to persistent evil within the same canon that affirms God's love toward sinners in Romans 5:8. The two are not contradictory predicates: love as essential disposition and settled moral hatred of evil operate at different levels, and the lexical stock (the vocabulary used in Scripture) keeps both without ranking either away.

Rom.9.13b · addressed

The 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) lexeme (word entry) itself carries an attested homonym (a same-spelled word with a different meaning). STEPbible-TBESH (a public lexicon) lists H2617 with two glosses, the dominant goodness, kindness, faithfulness sense and a rare 'reproach, shame' sense (as in Leviticus 20:17 and Proverbs 14:34). This polysemy (a word having more than one related meaning) is real but does not destabilize the verdict, because the covenant-love sense is overwhelmingly dominant across the 247 occurrences and is the sense in the Exodus 34:6 self-revelation. The minority sense never attaches to God as subject.

Concordance traversed

G0026, G0025, G2316, G1510, G3306, G3439, G4921, G5547, G1325, G5207, H2617, H0157, H0160

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

No anchor verse (1 John 4:8, 1 John 4:16, John 3:16, Romans 5:8, John 17:24, Exodus 34:6) falls within the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John 1:1 to 1:15, so this is not in_ecm_scope. The predicate noun 'love' (agape) in 'the God is love' (ho theos agape estin) is stable across the SBLGNT and Nestle1904 layers (two standard Greek New Testament editions) queried, with no flagged variant unit touching the linking-verb construction. The verdict does not turn on any disputed reading.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

love_as_divine_essence: affirms · Reads the qualitative predicate without the article 'the' (anarthrous qualitative predicate) 'love' (agape) in 'the God is love' (ho theos agape estin) as a statement about what God is, parallel to 'the God is light' (ho theos phos estin, 1 John 1:5) and 'spirit is the God' (pneuma ho theos, John 4:24). On this reading love is constitutive of the divine being, not an added quality, and John 17:24 confirms it is eternal and within the Trinity.

love_as_one_coequal_attribute: affirms_with_qualification · Grants that love is truly predicated of God but notes the same construction without the article 'the' (anarthrous predicate) also yields 'God is light' and 'God is spirit', so on grammar alone love is one of several essential predicates and is not lexically ranked above holiness or justice. This reading affirms the proposition while resisting any inference that love overrides God's other attributes, and it is fairly represented by the co-predication pattern (the same form used for several attributes side by side) in the text.

relational_dynamic_love: affirms_with_qualification · Reads divine love as essentially relational and self-giving, foregrounding the verb 'to love' (agapao) with God as subject acting toward the world (John 3:16, Romans 5:8). The pre-temporal Father-to-Son love of John 17:24, set before the foundation of the world, blocks any version of this reading that would make God's love contingent on or first activated by creation.

The verdict rests on grammatico-historical analysis (reading the text by its grammar in its historical setting) of the qualitative predicate-nominative construction without the article 'the' (anarthrous predicate nominative, a noun completing a 'X is Y' statement) in 1 John 4:8 and 4:16, read alongside the same author's parallel 'God is light' clause, the pre-temporal 'you loved me before the foundation of the world' (egapesas me pro kataboles kosmou) of John 17:24, and the Old Testament 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) self-revelation of Exodus 34:6. Analogia scripturae (the principle that Scripture interprets Scripture) harmonizes Romans 9:13 and Psalm 5:5. Progressive revelation (the gradual unfolding of doctrine across the canon) tracks the 'steadfast covenant love' (hesed) and 'to love' (ahav) vocabulary forward into the 'love' (agape) and 'to love' (agapao) group.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem (the question prompt) uses essence language (in His very essence) and intra-Trinitarian relation (the relationship of love among the persons of the Trinity). These are theological terms but they track directly to observable grammar: the qualitative predicate nominative without the article 'the' (anarthrous predicate nominative) of 1 John 4:8 and 4:16 supplies the essence claim, and the 'before the foundation of the world' (pro kataboles kosmou) clause of John 17:24 supplies the within-the-Trinity and eternal claim. The stem does not encode a single tradition's confessional taxonomy (denomination-specific category labels), so it is not verdict-preloaded (not pre-biased toward an answer). Cross-references were re-queried against the live store: the prior file labeled OpenBible edges as TSK with vote 1, and this pass corrects them to their real sources and vote counts, retaining 1 John 4:16 to 1 John 4:9 as TSK since that edge is present in TSK but not OpenBible.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.4.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.4.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.3.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.5.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.17.24
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.34.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0026

lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0025
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2617
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.4.8
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.17.24
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	John.3.16
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1John.4.8
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1John.4.16

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